

Chapter 3000: Memories of Oblivion.

Sunny had regained his fate and was remembered by the world.

Ironically enough, on the same day, the memories of most humans in the world were wiped clean of the events that had transpired in the last few years.

Some remembered more, while some remembered less, but almost no one remembered it all.

Needless to say, it was a mess.

In fact, it was a disaster. The entire world was thrust into a state of disorder and confusion, and the only thing that prevented it from sliding into a devastating panic was the fact that people who lived in the Age of the Nightmare Spell had developed a strong tolerance to peculiar calamities.

Some discovered themselves in new and unfamiliar places, having moved or resettled during the time that was missing from their memories. Some found out that their loved ones had passed. Some discovered that their children had grown, or that they were awaiting the birth of a new one.

Some people suddenly found themselves wielding Awakened powers, while others discovered that they had advanced to a new Rank, even if they could not remember having conquered a Nightmare.

It was a global crisis on an unimaginable scale, comparable only to the descent of the Nightmare Spell.

Humanity had learned how to better handle such a crisis, though.

Needless to say, every person who knew what had happened instantly became terribly busy in the immediate aftermath of the disaster.

In nqsc, Jet was barking orders in the conference hall of the government headquarters, pushing her dazed and disoriented subordinates to move.

Wake of Ruin was dead, but luckily, most of the high-ranking administrative personnel had survived the plague, so even if they did not know the details, they were able to begin working at mitigating the damage with a bit of guidance from Soul Reaper.

The government was the most important part of the solution, because it controlled the information channels and military forces of the waking world. However, even the great depths of its vast logistical network were not enough to deal with the consequences of the plague... or rather, of its cure.

In Ravenheart, Kai was trying to handle the situation despite having just experienced a traumatic encounter with a Cursed Devil... as well as the worst several months of his life.

In Bastion, Effie was commanding the escaped prisoners to take command of the people whom they had been fighting only hours earlier and pacify the reeling city together.

And on the Chained Isles, Nephis herself was taking charge of the great army of humanity.

Sunny was hiding in her shadow. Mordret whisked the white mist his predecessor had unleashed back into the eerie reaches of the Hollow Mountains and disappeared without a trace... from the looks of it, he wasn't keen on spending time with the other Supremes, or with any other human, really.

The Hollow Mountains welcomed him with boundless silence.

And Cassie...

Cassie was still asleep, having been utterly drained by the impossible undertaking of encompassing all of humanity in the invisible web of her Aspect.

It was unclear how long she would spend in the embrace of deep, rejuvenating slumber.

However, her life did not seem to be in danger, so all they could do was wait for her to wake up.

Sunny was busy, as well.

He had to retrieve Revel, Aiko, and the Shadow Clan from wherever it was that they had hidden themselves.

There was a disaster brewing on the Forgotten Shore, as well, from the looks of it, the ring of ancient barrows that surrounded the Burned Forest had begun to emanate some sort of ominous aura in his absence, and several hunting parties of the barrow wraiths appeared out of nowhere, ambushing for the Mimic.

That was a problem he would have to explore later, as well.

For now, though, in this time of turmoil and uncertainty, the agents of the Shadow Clan had a job to do. Their presence was desperately needed, so Sunny wanted to bring them back as soon as he could.

Everyone was terribly busy, and everyone had to do far more than what was humanly possible. The first twenty-four hours after the final confrontation against the Dreamspawn were especially chaotic, but on the other side of that day... a semblance of order started to reveal itself from the carnage.

People were still confused and disturbed, some mourning the loss of what they had forgotten, some having forgotten what they had lost. Others were coming to terms with suddenly discovering happiness they did not remember finding, instead...

But life went on.

Even if the soldiers stationed in nqsc did not remember how they had gotten to their posts that day, someone still had to man the walls of the quarantine zones established around the active Nightmare Gates, patrol the wasteland around the city, and watch over Sleepers undergoing their First Nightmares.

Even if doctors working in crowded hospitals did not remember the names of their patients, they still had to treat them. People had to feed their children, care for their elderly, and maintain the cities they lived in. Humanity had to continue moving forward... it had to recover and get back to work.

It began to recover, at least.

That was why, soon after the Dreamspawn was defeated, the members of the cohort arranged to meet in person at the Immortal Flame manor in nqsc. Their informal meeting was going to be followed by an emergency assembly of all the key figures of the Human Domain, but for now, the cohort was gathering in private.

Sunny arrived with a special guest, as well.

"Uncle Sunny..."

Little Ling was holding his hand as they emerged from the shadows in one of the corridors of Neph's manor. Sunny spared him a look.

"What?"

The little boy grinned.

"Can I have a nightmare horse, too? Please? Pretty please?"

Sunny chuckled.

"A fan of Nightmare, are you? Well, sorry to disappoint you. There's no horse like Nightmare anywhere in the world."

Were there even horses left in the world? Sunny was not sure.

They approached a private lounge hidden in the depths of the manor. Little Ling could not hear the voices yet, but Sunny could. A hesitant smile appeared on his lips.

Inside, Effie was speaking:

"What do you mean, his fate was stolen by a vile bird? What kind of... how does that even work? Ah, never mind!"

She fell silent...

But not for long.

"So he left us at Verge to go have a fight with a bird, then came back four years later... to open a shop in Bastion?"

She paused for a moment before mumbling:

"Actually, he always wanted to run a Memory shop. I guess dreams do come true... good for you, doofus."

Then, she suddenly yelled:

"But wait! There's more! He also seduced our poor, naive Nephis! The scoundrel!"

Sunny almost stumbled.

Neph's even voice resounded from behind the closed door.

"Who says that it wasn't me who seduced him?"

Effie seemed to have given her a look of pity.

"Oh, please..."

Nephis responded in the same reserved tone.

"But wasn't it you who suggested that I should... hmm... how exactly did you put it? Oh, yes..."

Effie's voice suddenly rose an octave.

"I did not! I absolutely did not! Your memory is messed up... because of Cassie. That's why you think that I said all those things about Sunny. You know, about how he is... he is..."

She fell silent and then said in a shaky tone:

".. He's standing right behind me, isn't he?"

Sunny, who had opened the door a moment earlier, smiled.

"He is."

Then, a deafening shout made him wince.

"Mommy!"

Little Ling dashed forward and slammed into Effie with all his Transcendent strength. Any other mother would have probably been sent crashing through the wall by the unbridled enthusiasm of his embrace, but she just swayed faintly, glanced down, and wrapped her hands around the boy.

Sunny watched them with a dubious smile. The scene was so overly sweet that his teeth hurt. It was a good thing that the little menace had only asked him for an infernal horse...

In the next moment, however, someone slammed into him, as well.

"Sunny!"

Sunny was dazed for a moment.

‘What is happening?’

Who was hugging him tightly enough to make him feel like he was suffocating?

‘Oh, right... it's that fool.’

Of course, it was Kai.

"Yeah... good to see you too, buddy. Now, can you let go of me?"

Instead of answering, Kai just hugged him tighter.

Sunny let out a heavy sigh and glanced at Jet, who was sitting on a chair some distance away.

His eyes were saying:

"Please, help!"

Jet studied him for a few seconds, then raised an eyebrow.

“What? You want me to join the hug, Sunny?”

He considered it for a moment, looked at Nephis, then shook his head.

Jet chuckled.

Then, a smile appeared on her lips, a rare soft smile that he had not seen grace her face before, and that suited her too well.

“It is good to have you back, Sunny. It's really... really good to have you back.”

Sunny remained silent for a short while. Eventually, he exhaled slowly.

"It's good to be back, everyone."

Nephis, Cassie, Effie, Kai, Jet...

Seeing them, he finally felt... at home. There were a lot of things he had to do. The world was able to remember him once more, but for most people who had known him, that simply meant that they considered him dead, buried under snow somewhere in Antarctica. Only those who had met the Lord of Shadows or Master Sunless face-to-face would know the truth, and out of them, most believed that the Lord of Shadows was gone.

That meant two things. First, that there was no threat of the Forgotten God waking up because of him. And second... that he had a lot of explaining to do.

In the near future, Sunny would have to visit a few people. Teacher Julius, Saint Tyris... Naeve was probably very confused at the moment. Sunny would finally be able to congratulate Quentin on surviving the Second Nightmare in a meaningful way, and give Kim and Luster his official blessing. There were others, as well.

And, of course... there was Rain.

But for now, Sunny simply wanted to enjoy the company of his friends.

He wanted to ask for their forgiveness, too, even if they did not seem to hold his decision against him... even if he knew that he would make the same decision again. He had waited for his friends to greet him, knowing who he was, for so long...

Sunny let out a heavy sigh.

Then, he said:

“Alright. Get in here, fool...”

With that, he wrapped his hands around Kai and hugged him back.

"This is a one-time thing, okay? Don't get any ideas!"

Despite the dire state of the world, here and now, it suddenly felt... like things were going to be alright.

Like their future was bright, and there was hope for them, still.

Some time later, when the rest of the cohort left to attend the emergency assembly, Sunny stayed behind and slowly made his way to the upper floor of the manor. There, he knocked on a door and waited patiently for an answer.

Eventually, the voice of a young woman resounded from the room inside:

"It's open!"

He hesitated for a moment, then opened the door and walked inside.

The room was spacious and brightly lit. There, Rain was sitting behind a desk, writing something down on a piece of synthetic paper.

Hearing his footsteps, she glanced up and smiled.

"Hey."

Sunny lingered a bit, then closed the door behind him.

"Hey, Rain. Oh... Ascended Rain, I mean. Congratulations."

She grimaced.

"I don't even remember becoming a Master, so... it's a bit peculiar. But thank you."

Rain glanced away.

"Anyway, I've been told to rest and recuperate. The world seems to be going crazy outside, but it's all peace and quiet here on the upper floor. I think Neph's mom is in the next room over... Cassie was sleeping in a room across the hall, but since she's awake now, it's just me."

Sunny nodded slowly.

"Rain..."

She drew a shaky breath and then glanced at him, her lips trembling a little.

After a long while, she said quietly:

"You've been watching over me this whole time. Long before we met in that convenience store... long before you told me who you are. That you and I are family."

Sunny nodded slowly.

"Yes."

Her smile faltered for a moment.

"But why? Why didn't you tell me sooner?"

Sunny remained silent for a long while, remembering his younger self.

In the end, he said simply:

"Because you didn't need me."

Rain turned away.

Sunny hesitated a little, then walked over and put his hand on her shoulder.

"But, for what it's worth... thank you."

"You might not have needed me... but looking back, I needed you very much, Rain. So, thank you for storming up to me that day, years ago, and calling me a brat. I don't think I would have ever gathered the courage to talk to you otherwise. Thank you for being alive, Rain, and for being who you are."

He glanced away, his smile turning softer.

"Look how far we've come, Rain. Not too bad for two orphans from the outskirts, isn't it?"

She glanced up at him, intense emotions burning in her eyes.

Eventually, she took a deep breath and said:

"You... do you remember what you told me before going to Antarctica? You told me that you'd be staying in the waking world this time, and that I could message you whenever. You told me not to be a stranger... that was seven years ago, Sunny! What the hell? Weren't you supposed to be the most honest person in the world, brother?"

Sunny grinned.

"Two worlds, actually."

Rain laughed, tears glistening in her eyes.

She paused for a moment, as if remembering something, and then said in a stunned voice:

"Wait, you're my brother... but you still charged me a fee for our lessons? At premium rate, mind you!"

Sunny cleared his throat.

"Why wouldn't it be premium? Your brother is quite an awesome teacher, you know."

Rain's gaze turned perilous.

"Oh, don't I know it! Don't I know it well!"

Sounds of laughter resounded in the corridors of the old manor, dispelling the silence.

Sunny had missed this laughter. But now, he didn't have to miss anything, ever again.

Days later, far away, two figures emerged from the shadows of the Forgotten Shore. One of them was Sunny, and the other was Asterion, bound, drained of essence, and barely able to walk.

He had spent the last few days sealed in the sorcerous circle on the underground floor of the Nameless Temple, in the company of Sunny's new Shadow. That kept the Dreamspawn contained for a while... but it wasn't going to contain him for long.

So, Sunny had come up with a different solution.

He pulled on the black chain, forcing Asterion to follow him up a tall mountain of rubble.

They were climbing the remains of the Crimson Spire, while the battlefield where the Dreamer Army had made its last stand loomed in the distance behind them.

"What a... charming place."

Asterion's voice was hoarse, but he still maintained his composure.

Sunny did not answer.

Instead, he continued forward until they finally reached their destination.

At the heart of the towering ruin, a deep well brimmed with darkness.

Far below, on the bottom of the well, there was a circle of black water, its surface flawlessly smooth... like a dark mirror. Asterion glanced down, a grim expression settling on his face.

Eventually, he turned to face Sunny and smiled.

"So, this is it, then?"

A hint of malevolent amusement ignited in his golden eyes.

"This is where you intend to seal me? What a lovely choice! Ah, but you must know that I will escape this seal, too, just like I escaped the Moon. One day, I will break free."

Sunny studied him for a while, his eyes full of somber consideration.

Then, he smiled faintly.

"Sure. I know you will."

Sunny took a deep breath and glanced around.

"But it will take you a long time. And by the time you escape... we will either be gods, or there won't be anyone left for you to devour."

Sunny faced Asterion.

"Do you see, Dreamspawn? Yes, I might not be able to destroy an idea..."

He raised his hand slowly.

"But I can make it obsolete."

With that, Sunny smiled and pushed Asterion into the well.

Into the cold embrace of the Dark Sea.

The Dreamspawn disappeared into the black water with a scream, and it swallowed him whole, suffocating the dark malice of his voice.

The water rippled a few times...

And grew still.

Soon, there was no trace of disturbance left on his surface, and no trace of him left under the lightless sky of the Forgotten Shore.

The story of the Dreamspawn was over, and new stories were about to begin in his wake.

Far away, at the estuary of the River of Tears, Ananke disembarked from a ship and jumped onto the soil of the Dream Realm. Her escorts stayed back, giving her space. She glanced down with an uncertain expression, unfamiliar with the feeling of a boundless expanse of solid ground under her feet. It was all so bizarre that she felt like her days were spent wandering the peculiar new world in a daze.

There were no impenetrable walls of black stone behind the azure sky. There was only a single sun traversing its vast expanse. People aged with the passage of time and died of old age while remaining in place.

It was all strange and unfamiliar... but not unwelcome.

Because this world was alive.

It was full of life.

And she was going to give her people a new life in this vast, vibrant world.

Ananke remained motionless for a long while, then pulled the seven bone amulets from beneath her mantle.

Her melodious voice resounded on the misty shores of the Stormsea, whispering the Names of Return and Liberation.

Countless figures slowly began to appear around her, hazy at first, then more and more solid.

She welcomed them with a smile.

“Ananke of Weave... greets the River People!”

On the other side of the Dream Realm, in the fractured halls of the Ebony Tower, Cassie inhaled deeply.

She was standing in the middle of a dimly lit chamber. Nothing adorned the black stone, and no one was keeping her company.

She was alone in the darkness.

Cassie had come here to call upon the power of her Aspect.

It was as Asterion had said, she could only manifest one Supreme being, and she was

already manifesting herself. Things were a bit better if she wanted to manifest a Transcendent, though. She could manifest a Transcendent Titan or seven Transcendent Beasts. She could also manifest Memories of that Rank... but manifesting beings or items of that Rank drained her essence. Maintaining the summoning permanently would present a problem.

However, doing so with memories of lesser Ranks was quite possible. She could sustain thousands of Dormant Memories in existence indefinitely, for example, if she so wished to.

Of course, Cassie had no need for a thousand Dormant Memories.

But she had something else in mind.

A cold wind seemed to blow across the dark chamber, and suddenly, there was a man of around her age kneeling on the stones in front of her.

The man seemed dazed and disoriented, gasping for breath. He was also entirely naked, so she picked up a folded blanket from a pile of them and wrapped it around his shoulders.

The man flinched and glanced at her, his eyes fresh with a memory of terrible pain. For a moment, he seemed stunned by her sublime beauty.

But then, a hint of recognition slowly appeared on his face.

The man groaned, then asked in a hoarse voice:

"You are... Cassia? Aren't you?"

Cassie nodded.

"I am. You must be confused... allow me to explain. Many years have passed since we saw each other last, and many things have happened in those years. I have brought you back from beyond the grave because despite all our differences... I believe that the world needs your potential."

She straightened and glanced at the kneeling man with a solemn expression. Then, she said:

“Sleeper Gunlaug! Welcome back to the world of the living.”

And soon, she repeated these words once more.

“Sleeper Kido! Welcome back to the world of the living...”

"Sleeper Gemma..."

“Sleeper Park...”

"Sleeper Stev..."

“Sleeper Jubei...”

She called their names one after another, until her voice grew hoarse and her head grew heavy.

On that day, the Dreamers of the Dark City finally returned from the crimson labyrinth of the Forgotten Shore.

And she wasn't alone in the darkness anymore.

[End of volume eleven: The Song of Ariadne.]